



1000 B.C.—around the time the Ramayana events are said to have happened. There are clear signs of major structures having come up on the disputed site after 5th century A.D., which indicated that it was either a religious or administrative centre. There were pillars bearing figures of Hindu deities. In the other five sites, ASI was able to establish antiquity, confirming that they dated back to the first quarter of the first millennium B.C. The cultural material obtained in the form of shards of pottery indicated that they belonged to remarkably similar time frames. Experts say that despite the wealth of findings, the excavations did not throw up direct proof of Ram's existence. But Lal maintains: "We have ample archaeological evidence sustaining the historicity of Ram from a period well before the Christian era."

In his support, Lal cites a terracotta plaque from Kausambi at the Allahabad Museum, ascribable to the 2nd century B.C., which depicts the scene of Sita's abduction. The other evidence is a set of terracotta panels from

AYODHYA: Site excavations (far left); a frieze that was recovered

Haryana, dating back to the 2nd and 3rd century A.D., at the Los Angeles County Museum, depicting a specific scene from the Ramayana story explained in an inscription in Brahmi script. Lal asks: "Did these ancient artists portray these detailed scenes from the Ramayana, with the intention of bluffing us in the 21st century?" Valmiki's Ramayana is said to have been written in 3rd century B.C.

Most experts now call for a marine archaeological survey that could at least shed some light over whether there was any human involvement in the formation of Adam's Bridge. It was something the Ministry of Culture should have insisted on in the first place before allowing ASI, which comes under it, to file such an affidavit. Says B.R. Pande, a former ASI director of archaeology, "ASI is being made a scapegoat in the Sethusamudram Project. It should now be asked to do some underwater excavations to check if there is any archaeological evidence." It may delay the project by at least a year, but it would help ease the rapidly escalating tension over the Ram issue.

with inputs from Senthil Kumar in Chennai



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